

with nothing except what they could carry in their suitcases, and he realized that he would best be able to support them by performing as a concert pianist, especially in the lucrative US market. From this point, composing became virtually a sideline in his career: although he lived for another quarter of a century, he wrote only six new works during this period. In addition to his concerts and recitals (typically he gave about 70–80 each year), he flourished in the recording studio, leaving a rich legacy of disks, including accounts of his four piano concertos.

“ I cannot **cast out** the **old way** of **writing**,
and I cannot **acquire** the **new**. ”

SERGEI RACHMANINOFF, 1939

During his lifetime, Rachmaninoff was regarded as one of the greatest pianists who ever lived—a reputation that endures today. He mesmerized audiences with his stage presence and his extraordinary musicianship. Exceptionally tall, with hair cropped almost like a convict and a stone-faced demeanor, he was described by Stravinsky as a “six-and-a-half-foot scowl.” His severe manner belied the passion and poetry of his playing and also the warmth and wit he displayed in private. He was generous, too: after his concerts and records made him wealthy, he regularly sent money to Russia to help people in need.

For two decades, Rachmaninoff divided his time between the US and Europe, but in 1939, with war imminent, he settled